Every other day for the past month, I've gotten on the back of a motorcycle, plugged in my eight-dollar wireless headphones, and picked a podcast for my thirty-minute ride to Telugu class. I'm a big fan of History on Fire. It's narrated by an Italian Professor who talks for hours about dramatic tales and epics filled with great characters and conflicts. I'm quite partial to his series on Sitting Bull.

Listening to smart people speak into microphones is my favorite part of a commute. I remember the joy of discovering NPR while my dad dropped my sister and I off at school and listening to hosts of *Invisibilia* talk about emotions. I discovered Daniel Denvir's penchant for asking three questions in one when I started listening to *The Dig*. Most recently, I've been listening to Ezra Klein. Specifically, Ezra Klein on Artificial Intelligence.

I like Ezra Klein. He's a good listener. His last two episodes featured Jensen Huang and Bill Gates and their drastically different takes on the future AI. Huang argues against regulation—the frontier labs, if they're so worried about misaligned AI—can police themselves. If a product is bad, don't ship it. Government need not be involved. The economy will go through a transition, but new industries will create new jobs for workers to fill.

Gates expects AI to displace millions of workers because the last comparative advantage possessed by people (cognition) will no longer be a scarce resource. He expects this to hit hardest in the Global North where economies are built on knowledge and service sectors. Also, AI can create bioweapons that could kill us all.

There's no shortage of takes on the implications of AI. Timnit Gebru sits on the other side of the spectrum. The discourse around AI as superintelligent and a technology functioning beyond our capacity, she suggests, is bullshit. The frontier labs, with their upcoming IPOs and stiff competition, have every incentive to describe their technology in ways that inspire awe and drive up their stock price. The existential threat, in Gebru's view, is to inflate what AI is capable of: evidenced by the U.S military almost seizing a Chinese ship because an AI written memo stated it was carrying nuclear missiles. The real concern comes from a less-than-intelligent, fallible tool being used to kill schoolchildren in Iran.

I take out my headphones.

I get off the motorcycle, walk upstairs to my teacher's apartment, and cram for three minutes in advance of my Telugu vocabulary test.

AI has me developing arguments for why I do things that I've never had to develop before. Perhaps my efforts towards Telugu fluency were already pointless. Lots of people in India speak English. My cousins, native speakers, speak half their sentences in English. Now, with AI promises of instantaneous translation, should I be learning to vide code instead of looking at Quizlet? My family group chat certainly thinks so.

Before moving to China, I worked in environmental justice policy. And the environmental implications of AI use feel confusing. The energy and water demands of a single query in ChatGPT seem overblown, but the collective electricity demand of major tech companies has them immolating their climate goals with natural gas. At the same time, there are new innovative technologies using AI to improve grid connectivity or accelerate advanced geothermal energy. Does using Claude for my cover letters make me a bad environmentalist?[1] What does it mean to be an ethical user of AI? Is that possible?

What's most frustrating is how little agency I feel in the era of AI. It feels suffocatingly mandatory. When my grandmother watches AI slop on her phone I don't know how to articulate my discomfort. When AI is used to kill people more effectively, I do know how to articulate my discomfort, but I don't know what to do about it. AI seems to be shaping our world with the promises of efficiency, abundance, more life, and more death. And yet, there must be ways to stop the bad and amplify the good of what AI can offer us.

What I crave is an understanding of AI that's rooted in progressive values. I want people to have economic security, to live in a planet that's not burning, a strong sense of community, silly things like healthcare, and a sense of their humanity. Maybe AI has a serious role to play in advancing these ideals. Maybe not. What the Left needs is a coherent set of values that inform what role AI plays in our world, and one that extends beyond "data centers are bad."

It pains me to admit this.

What I crave… is a framework.

In the coming weeks, I'll explore the following concepts:

1) Control: Who is in control of AI technologies? What are the implications of that control? If control needs to change, could that happen? How so? What are the different models of governance available to us and how could we practically achieve them?
2) Political Economy: Is AI reshaping the economy? If so, how? In what ways does AI get us closer to or farther from our ideal form of living? How does the vision for the future held by AI industrialists compare to that of the Left?
3) Climate: What are the material implications of AI? How does the AI industry's climate impacts compare to other sectors of the economy? What do protests over data centers teach us about corporate interests and local organizing—and how much is the environment what's driving resistance?

I'll need to ask my teacher how to write "existential dread, maybe?" in Telugu.

[1] To my future employer—the only advanced technology I write my cover letters with is love.